



picture-post card material. As ideas of beauty change, so does the value that society places on it. The paintings by Dutch artist Vincent van Gogh (1853–1890) were once thought crude and shocking. Today, his bright canvases are considered beautiful. They are also among the world's most valuable works of art.

PRETTY AS A PICTURE

Artists have always painted beautiful women, but they rarely match our modern perceptions of beauty. For a start, they are much plumper than is considered attractive today. In the past, if you were overweight, it meant you had a lot to eat and were therefore rich—and desirable. Today, the opposite is true. The thinner you are, the more time you may have spent in expensive gyms working off the weight. Similarly, pale skin was once considered the height of beauty because tanned skin was associated with people who worked outside. This changed when beach vacations became the mark of the wealthy, and suntanned skin was deemed attractive. Girls belonging to the Padaung people of eastern Myanmar

(Burma) were fitted with bronze neck rings from the age of about five. New rings were added at certain times, so when a girl was old enough to marry, her neck had been stretched by 10 in (25 cm). This probably seems ugly and deforming to people from other cultures, but not to the Padaung. Neck rings enhanced a woman's beauty and also gave her family social status.

PERFECT SYMMETRY

Scientific studies show that most people find the evenly balanced features of symmetrical faces more beautiful than asymmetric ones. Biologists believe that there is a genetic reason for this. Disease and infections during physical growth can cause small imperfections, so if someone has smooth and even features, it is a sign that they have a good immune system and will produce healthy babies. The wish to follow a media ideal of “perfect” beauty makes some people resort to plastic surgery to change their facial features or body parts. However, by conforming to stereotypes, a person's natural beauty—what makes them unique and special—is lost.